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Human Values in Vedic Darsana

BOE101

One-day revision notes: definitions, solved examples, code and important questions

Program: B.Tech | **Branches:** ALL | **Semester:** 8 | **Credits:** 3 | **L-T-P:** 3-0-0

Scheme: AKTU B.Tech 4th year, Open Elective-IV, 2025-26 onwards

UNIT 1	UNIT 2	UNIT 3	UNIT 4	UNIT 5
Vedic Literature, Origin of Darsana and Nyaya Darsana	Vaisheshika Darsana	Samkhya, Yoga and Basics of Vedanta	Isha and Taittiriya Upanishads	Varna, Ashrama, Pancha Maha Yajna, Samskaras and Vratas

Original revision notes written for the AKTU syllabus, covering the human values in the Vedic darshanas (schools of philosophy) and the Upanishads. Every unit has the same parts:

1. **2-mark definitions**: short answers you can write word for word in Section A, with the Sanskrit term in brackets.
2. **Core concepts**: the teachings explained step by step, with tables and lists.
3. **Examples and comparisons**: everyday situations that show the ideas.
4. **Key points to remember**.
5. **Important questions**: the long questions to prepare, with what your answer must contain.

How to use these notes the day before the paper

- **Morning (3 hours):** Unit 1 (Vedic literature, the six darshanas, Nyaya's sixteen categories, four pramanas and five-member syllogism) and Unit 2 (Vaisheshika's six categories, definition of dharma, cause and effect, karma and its results, removing attachment and aversion).
- **Afternoon (3 hours):** Unit 3 (Samkhya's purusha, prakriti, 25 tattvas and three gunas; Yoga's eight limbs, kleshas, vrittis and samyama; Vedanta's atma, five koshas and four-fold qualification).
- **Evening (2 hours):** Unit 4 (Isha Upanishad on renunciation and action; Taittiriya Upanishad on the five sheaths and liberation) and Unit 5 (varna and ashrama, five great daily duties, sixteen samskaras, vratas), then the "Last-hour checklist".
- **In the exam:** write the Sanskrit term with its meaning, quote the key line (for example "yogash chitta-vritti-nirodhah") with a translation, and add a modern example. Lists such as the 16 padarthas, 25 tattvas and 8 limbs are frequent 7-mark questions.

AKTU paper pattern (theory, 70 marks, 3 hours): Section A has 7 short questions of 2 marks, all compulsory (14). Section B has 5 questions of 7 marks, attempt any 3 (21). Section C has 5 questions (one per unit), each with two parts, attempt one part of each, 7 marks each (35). Every unit gets its own Section C question, so do not skip any unit.

UNIT 1 Vedic Literature, Origin of Darsana and Nyaya Darsana

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Veda:** from "vid", to know; the oldest sacred texts of India, considered shruti (heard or revealed knowledge).
- **Shruti and smriti:** shruti is revealed knowledge (the Vedas, including the Upanishads); smriti is remembered tradition composed by sages (Dharmashastras, epics, Puranas).
- **Darsana (darshana):** literally "seeing" or "vision"; a system of philosophy that gives a view of reality, knowledge and the goal of life.
- **Shad darsana:** the six orthodox (astika) schools: Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Samkhya, Yoga, Purva Mimamsa and Uttara Mimamsa (Vedanta).
- **Nyaya:** the school of logic and reasoning founded by Gautama (Akshapada), author of the Nyaya Sutra.
- **Pramana:** a valid means of knowledge; Nyaya accepts four: perception, inference, comparison and verbal testimony.
- **Pratyaksha (perception):** knowledge arising from contact of a sense organ with its object.
- **Anumana (inference):** knowledge of something not perceived, based on a known invariable relation (vyapti), for example inferring fire from smoke.
- **Vyapti:** the universal, invariable relation between the reason (hetu) and what is to be proved (sadhya): "wherever there is smoke, there is fire".
- **Hetvabhasa:** a fallacy of reason, a reason that looks valid but is not.

💡 Core concepts

Vedic literature:

- **Four Vedas:**
- Rigveda: hymns of praise; oldest, about 1500–1200 BCE.
- Yajurveda: formulas for rituals; Shukla (white) and Krishna (black) branches.
- Samaveda: melodies for chanting.
- Atharvaveda: daily life, healing and society.
- **Four layers of each Veda:**
- Samhita: mantras and hymns.
- Brahmana: explanation of rituals.
- Aranyaka: forest texts, meditation on ritual.
- Upanishad: philosophy, the end of the Veda, so "Vedanta".
- **Six Vedangas (limbs):**
- Shiksha (phonetics).
- Kalpa (ritual and conduct).
- Vyakarana (grammar).

- Nirukta (etymology).
- Chhandas (metre).
- Jyotisha (astronomy and time).
- **Upavedas:** Ayurveda (medicine), Dhanurveda (archery and warfare), Gandharvaveda (music and arts), Sthapatyaveda or Arthashastra (architecture, polity).

Origin of darsana:

- The Upanishads raised deep questions: what is the self, what is reality, how do we end suffering.
- To answer them systematically, sages composed short aphorisms (sutras), which later commentators explained.
- All schools aim at freedom from suffering (moksha) through right knowledge, but differ in method and metaphysics.

The six orthodox darsanas

Darsana	Founder and text	Main focus
Nyaya	Gautama, Nyaya Sutra	Logic, means of valid knowledge
Vaisheshika	Kanada, Vaisheshika Sutra	Categories of reality, atomism
Samkhya	Kapila; Samkhya Karika of Ishvarakrishna	Dualism of purusha and prakriti, evolution
Yoga	Patanjali, Yoga Sutra	Discipline of the mind, eight limbs
Purva Mimamsa	Jaimini, Mimamsa Sutra	Dharma as Vedic duty and ritual
Uttara Mimamsa (Vedanta)	Badarayana (Vyasa), Brahma Sutra	Brahman and atman, liberation through knowledge

The schools are often paired: Nyaya-Vaisheshika, Samkhya-Yoga and Mimamsa-Vedanta.

Nyaya: sixteen categories (padarthas):

1. Pramana: means of valid knowledge.
2. Prameya: objects of valid knowledge.
3. Samshaya: doubt.
4. Prayojana: purpose.
5. Drishtanta: example.
6. Siddhanta: established tenet.
7. Avayava: members of a syllogism.
8. Tarka: hypothetical reasoning.
9. Nirnaya: ascertainment or conclusion.
10. Vada: honest discussion to find truth.
11. Jalpa: debate aimed only at victory.
12. Vitanda: destructive criticism without stating one's own view.
13. Hetvabhasa: fallacious reason.
14. Chala: quibbling (twisting words).
15. Jati: futile rejoinder.

16. Nigrahasthana: point of defeat.

Twelve prameyas (objects to be known): self (atma), body (sharira), senses (indriya), sense objects (artha), cognition (buddhi), mind (manas), activity (pravritti), faults (dosha), rebirth (pretyabhava), fruit (phala), suffering (duhkha) and liberation (apavarga).

Four pramanas:

- **Pratyaksha** (perception).
- **Anumana** (inference): for oneself (svartha) and for others (parartha).
- **Upamana** (comparison or analogy): a city person told "a gavaya (wild ox) is like a cow" recognizes one in the forest.
- **Shabda** (reliable verbal testimony, apta vachana).

Five-member syllogism (panchavayava)

Member	Sanskrit	Example
1. Proposition	Pratijna	The hill has fire.
2. Reason	Hetu	Because it has smoke.
3. Example	Udaharana	Whatever has smoke has fire, as in a kitchen.
4. Application	Upanaya	This hill has smoke (which is always with fire).
5. Conclusion	Nigamana	Therefore, the hill has fire.

Path to liberation in Nyaya (Nyaya Sutra 1.1.2): suffering (duhkha) comes from birth (janma), birth from activity (pravritti), activity from faults (dosha: attachment, aversion, delusion), and faults from false knowledge (mithya jnana). When false knowledge is removed by true knowledge of the sixteen categories, each later link disappears in turn, leading to apavarga (liberation).

Values from Nyaya: clear thinking, testing claims with evidence, honest discussion (vada) instead of mere winning (jalpa) or attacking (vitanda), and avoiding fallacies and quibbling. These are exactly the habits of a good engineer and citizen.

Examples and comparisons

Example 1 (syllogism in engineering). Proposition: this bearing is overheating. Reason: because its housing temperature is 95 °C. Example: whenever a bearing housing exceeds 80 °C, the bearing is overheating, as seen in earlier failures. Application: this housing is at 95 °C. Conclusion: so this bearing is overheating and must be checked.

Example 2 (vada vs jalpa in a meeting). In vada, a team discusses two designs to find the better one and accepts evidence. In jalpa, one person argues only to win, ignoring data. Nyaya teaches us to practise vada.

Key points to remember

- Four Vedas; four layers (Samhita, Brahmana, Aranyaka, Upanishad); six Vedangas; four Upavedas.
- Six darsanas with founders and texts; three pairs.
- Nyaya's 16 padarthas; 12 prameyas; 4 pramanas; vyapti.

- Five-member syllogism: pratijna, hetu, udaharana, upanaya, nigamana.
- Chain: false knowledge → faults → activity → birth → suffering; reverse it for liberation.

⭐ Important questions

1. Describe the structure of Vedic literature (Vedas, layers, Vedangas, Upavedas).
2. How did the darsanas originate? List the six orthodox darsanas with their founders and focus.
3. Explain the sixteen padarthas of Nyaya darsana.
4. Explain the four pramanas of Nyaya. Illustrate the five-member syllogism with an example.
5. What human values does Nyaya darsana teach? Explain the Nyaya path to liberation.

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UNIT 2 Vaisheshika Darsana

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Vaisheshika:** the school founded by Kanada (author of the Vaisheshika Sutra) that classifies all reality into categories; its name comes from "vishesha" (particularity).
- **Padartha:** literally "meaning of a word"; a category of everything that can be known and named.
- **Dravya (substance):** the substratum of qualities and actions; there are nine.
- **Guna (quality):** a property that resides in a substance but has no qualities or actions itself (such as colour, taste, number, pleasure, pain).
- **Karma (action, motion):** movement in a substance; five kinds: upward, downward, contraction, expansion and going.
- **Samanya (universal):** the common nature shared by many things, such as "cowness" in all cows.
- **Vishesha (particularity):** the ultimate distinguishing feature of each eternal substance (each atom, each soul).
- **Samavaya (inherence):** the inseparable relation between a whole and its parts, a substance and its quality, and so on (cloth and threads).
- **Paramanu (atom):** the smallest, eternal, indivisible particle of earth, water, fire or air.
- **Adrishta:** the "unseen" force, the stored merit and demerit of past actions, which shapes future experience.

💡 Core concepts

Six padarthas (later a seventh, abhava, was added)

Padartha	Meaning	Examples
Dravya	Substance (nine kinds)	Earth, water, fire, air, ether (akasha), time (kala), space or direction (dik), self (atma), mind (manas)
Guna	Quality (24 kinds)	Colour, taste, smell, touch, number, size, pleasure, pain, desire, aversion, effort, merit, demerit and so on
Karma	Action or motion (5 kinds)	Throwing up, throwing down, contracting, expanding, going
Samanya	Universal	Cowness, humanness
Vishesha	Particularity	What distinguishes one atom from another
Samavaya	Inherence	Relation of threads and cloth, quality and substance
Abhava (added later)	Non-existence	Absence of a pot on the table

Atomism: physical things are made of eternal atoms (paramanu) of four elements. Two atoms make a dyad (dvyanuka), three dyads make a triad (tryanuka), the smallest visible particle (like a dust mote in

sunlight). Creation and dissolution are the joining and separation of atoms, guided by adrishta and, in later Nyaya-Vaisheshika, by God.

Definition of dharma (Vaisheshika Sutra 1.1.2): "yato'bhyudaya-nihshreyasa-siddhih sa dharmah". That which leads to both worldly well-being (abhyudaya) and the highest good, liberation (nihshreyasa), is dharma. So dharma is not just ritual. It covers right actions that bring prosperity in this life and spiritual freedom, which is a balanced view of values.

Cause and effect (karya-karana):

- Vaisheshika holds **asatkaryavada** (arambhavada): the effect is a new creation that did not exist before in the cause (the cloth is new, not hidden in the threads).
- **Three kinds of causes:**
- **Samavayi karana** (inherent or material cause): threads for a cloth.
- **Asamavayi karana** (non-inherent cause): the conjunction of threads.
- **Nimitta karana** (efficient or instrumental cause): the weaver and the loom.
- **Value:** every result has causes. Wanting good results while ignoring their causes is irrational, so responsibility follows.

Karma and its results:

- Actions done with desire produce merit (dharma) or demerit (adharma), stored as adrishta in the self.
- These ripen as pleasure and pain in this life or later, and drive rebirth.
- Actions done without attachment do not bind.

Removing attachment and aversion (raga-dvesha):

- Attachment and aversion arise from false knowledge (not seeing things as they are).
- Correct knowledge of the padarthas (understanding that the self is different from body and mind, and that pleasures are temporary) weakens raga and dvesha.
- Without raga and dvesha, actions produce no new adrishta; existing adrishta is used up; the self is freed from contact with mind and body. This is moksha, the end of all suffering.

Values from Vaisheshika: a scientific, analytical attitude (classification, atomism), causal responsibility, a balanced definition of dharma (prosperity and spiritual good), and freedom from attachment and hatred through right understanding.

Examples and comparisons

Example 3 (three causes of a product). For a smartphone: material (samavayi) causes are glass, metal and silicon; non-inherent (asamavayi) cause is the assembly or joining of parts; efficient (nimitta) causes are the engineers, robots and tools. A good result needs all three to be right.

Example 4 (abhyudaya and nihshreyasa). An engineer who earns honestly, supports family and society (abhyudaya) and also keeps inner peace and freedom from greed (towards nihshreyasa) follows dharma in Kanada's sense.

Example 5 (removing dvesha). A student dislikes a strict professor. Understanding the professor's role and the student's own benefit (right knowledge) reduces aversion, and the student learns better.

Key points to remember

- Kanada, Vaisheshika Sutra; six padarthas plus abhava; nine dravyas, 24 gunas, 5 karmas.
- Atomism: paramanu, dvyanuka, tryanuka; adrishta.
- Dharma: "yato'bhyudaya-nihshreyasa-siddhih sa dharmah".
- Asatkaryavada; three causes (samavayi, asamavayi, nimitta).
- Raga-dvesha come from false knowledge; right knowledge ends them and leads to moksha.

⭐ Important questions

1. Explain the six padarthas of Vaisheshika darsana with examples.
2. Explain the Vaisheshika definition of dharma and its relevance to human values.
3. Explain the Vaisheshika theory of cause and effect and the three kinds of causes.
4. Describe the Vaisheshika view of karma and its results.
5. How can attachment and aversion (raga-dvesha) be removed according to Vaisheshika? Explain atomism briefly.

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UNIT 3 Samkhya, Yoga and Basics of Vedanta

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Samkhya:** the dualistic school founded by Kapila, which explains reality by two principles, purusha and prakriti, and enumerates 25 tattvas.
- **Purusha:** pure consciousness; the witness; many in number, inactive and unchanging.
- **Prakriti:** primordial matter or nature; one, unconscious, active, made of three gunas, the source of all physical and mental evolution.
- **Gunas:** the three constituents of prakriti: sattva (light, purity, balance), rajas (activity, passion) and tamas (inertia, darkness).
- **Satkaryavada:** the theory that the effect already exists in its cause in a hidden form (curd is present in milk potentially).
- **Yoga (Patanjali):** "yogash chitta-vritti-nirodhah" (Yoga Sutra 1.2): yoga is the stilling of the fluctuations of the mind.
- **Klesha:** an affliction or root cause of suffering; Patanjali lists five.
- **Vritti:** a fluctuation or modification of the mind; Patanjali lists five kinds.
- **Samyama:** the combined practice of dharana, dhyana and samadhi on one object (Yoga Sutra 3.4).
- **Sadhana chatushtaya:** the four-fold qualification required of a seeker of Vedanta: discrimination, dispassion, six virtues and longing for liberation.

💡 Core concepts

Samkhya: 25 tattvas (24 from prakriti plus purusha)

Group	Tattvas	Count
Consciousness	Purusha	1
Primordial matter	Prakriti (mula prakriti)	1
Cosmic intellect	Mahat (buddhi)	1
Ego, sense of "I"	Ahamkara	1
Mind	Manas	1
Organs of knowledge	Ear, skin, eye, tongue, nose (jnanendriyas)	5
Organs of action	Speech, hands, feet, excretion, generation (karmendriyas)	5
Subtle elements	Sound, touch, form, taste, smell (tanmatras)	5
Gross elements	Space, air, fire, water, earth (mahabhutas)	5
Total		25

When purusha comes near prakriti, the balance of the gunas is disturbed and evolution begins: prakriti → mahat → ahamkara → (sattvic side) manas and ten senses; (tamasic side) five tanmatras → five mahabhutas.

Three gunas

Guna	Nature	In behaviour
Sattva	Light, purity, knowledge, balance	Calm, wise, kind, clear
Rajas	Activity, desire, restlessness	Ambitious, busy, passionate, anxious
Tamas	Inertia, heaviness, ignorance	Lazy, confused, careless, dull

All things contain all three gunas in different proportions. A person grows by moving from tamas to rajas to sattva.

Samkhya on suffering and liberation:

- **Three kinds of suffering:**
- Adhyatmika (from oneself: body and mind).
- Adhibhautika (from other beings).
- Adhidaivika (from natural or supernatural forces).
- Bondage is the confusion of purusha with prakriti (identifying with body and mind).
- Liberation (kaivalya, isolation) comes through discriminative knowledge (viveka) of their difference.
- Like a lame man (purusha, who can see) and a blind man (prakriti, who can move) cooperating, the two together produce experience; when purusha sees the truth, the play of prakriti stops for it, like a dancer who stops once seen.

Yoga of Patanjali:

- **Five vrittis:** right knowledge (pramana), error (viparyaya), imagination or verbal delusion (vikalpa), sleep (nidra) and memory (smriti). Each may be painful (klishta) or not painful.
- **Five kleshas:**
- Ignorance (avidya), the root of the others: taking the impermanent as permanent and the non-self as the self.
- Egoism (asmita).
- Attachment (raga).
- Aversion (dvesha).
- Clinging to life or fear of death (abhinivesha).
- **Means:** practice (abhyasa) and dispassion (vairagya); also kriya yoga (tapas, svadhyaya, ishvara pranidhana) to weaken the kleshas.

Eight limbs of yoga (ashtanga yoga)

Limb	Meaning	Content
1. Yama	Social restraints	Ahimsa (non-violence), satya (truth), asteya (non-stealing), brahmacharya (self-control), aparigraha (non-possessiveness)
2. Niyama	Personal observances	Shaucha (purity), santosha (contentment), tapas (discipline), svadhyaya (self-study), ishvara pranidhana (surrender to God)

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Limb	Meaning	Content
3. Asana	Posture	Steady and comfortable (sthira sukham asanam)
4. Pranayama	Breath regulation	Control of inhalation, exhalation and retention
5. Pratyahara	Withdrawal of senses	Senses turn away from objects
6. Dharana	Concentration	Fixing the mind on one place
7. Dhyana	Meditation	Unbroken flow of attention to that object
8. Samadhi	Absorption	Only the object shines; the sense of separate self fades

The first five are external aids (bahiranga); the last three are internal (antaranga), and together they form **samyama**, which gives deep knowledge of its object.

Basics of Vedanta:

- **Atma:** the true self, pure consciousness, different from body, senses and mind. In Advaita (Shankara) it is identical with Brahman: "aham brahmasmi", I am Brahman (Brihadaranyaka Upanishad); "tat tvam asi", you are That (Chandogya Upanishad).
- **Pancha kosha (five sheaths):** the self is covered by five layers: 1. Annamaya (food or physical body). 2. Pranamaya (vital energy). 3. Manomaya (mind and emotions). 4. Vijnanamaya (intellect and discernment). 5. Anandamaya (bliss).
- The atma is beyond all five.
- **Sadhana chatushtaya (four-fold qualification):** 1. **Viveka:** discrimination between the eternal and the non-eternal. 2. **Vairagya:** dispassion for enjoyments here and hereafter. 3. **Shat sampat (six virtues):** shama (control of mind), dama (control of senses), uparati (withdrawal or contentment), titiksha (forbearance), shraddha (faith) and samadhana (focus). 4. **Mumukshutva:** intense desire for liberation.

Examples and comparisons

Example 6 (gunas in study habits). A tamasic student sleeps through the alarm and postpones work. A rajasic student studies in bursts with anxiety about marks. A sattvic student studies regularly, calmly and with interest. Improving food, sleep and routine helps move from tamas toward sattva.

Example 7 (yama-niyama as a professional code). Truthfulness (satya) in reports, non-stealing (asteya) of others' code or ideas, contentment (santosha) instead of envy, and self-study (svadhyaya) to keep skills updated make a strong personal code of ethics.

Example 8 (five koshas and well-being). Healthy food and exercise (annamaya), breathing practice (pranamaya), managing emotions (manomaya), good judgement (vijnanamaya) and inner contentment (anandamaya) give a complete picture of well-being, not only physical fitness.

Key points to remember

- Samkhya: Kapila, Samkhya Karika; purusha and prakriti; 25 tattvas; three gunas; satkaryavada; three sufferings; kaivalya by viveka.

- Yoga: "yogash chitta-vritti-nirodhah"; 5 vrittis; 5 kleshas; abhyasa and vairagya; 8 limbs; samyama.
- Vedanta: atma = Brahman (Advaita); 5 koshas; sadhana chatushtaya with six virtues.

⭐ Important questions

1. Explain purusha and prakriti and the 25 tattvas of Samkhya darsana.
2. Explain the three gunas and their effect on human behaviour.
3. Explain the eight limbs of Patanjali's yoga. What is samyama?
4. Explain the five kleshas and five vrittis according to the Yoga Sutra.
5. Explain atma, the five koshas and the four-fold qualification (sadhana chatushtaya) in Vedanta.

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UNIT 4 Isha and Taittiriya Upanishads

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Upanishad:** literally "sitting near" (a teacher); the philosophical texts at the end of the Vedas that discuss Brahman, atman and liberation.
- **Isha (Ishavasya) Upanishad:** a short Upanishad of 18 verses that forms the last chapter (40th) of the Shukla Yajurveda (Vajasaneyi Samhita).
- **Tyaga (renunciation):** giving up the sense of ownership and greed, not necessarily giving up things or work.
- **Karma yoga:** performing one's duties without attachment to their fruits, so that action does not bind.
- **Vidya and avidya (in the Isha):** knowledge of the Self and knowledge of works or the world; the Isha says both must be understood together.
- **Taittiriya Upanishad:** an Upanishad of the Krishna Yajurveda with three sections (vallis): Shiksha Valli, Brahmananda Valli and Bhrigu Valli.
- **Brahman:** the ultimate reality; Taittiriya defines it as "satyam jnanam anantam brahma", Brahman is truth, knowledge and infinity.
- **Pancha kosha:** the five sheaths that cover the self, taught in the Brahmananda and Bhrigu Vallis.
- **Mukti (moksha):** liberation; "brahmavid apnoti param", the knower of Brahman attains the highest.
- **Convocation address (Shiksha Valli 1.11):** the teacher's final advice to students leaving the gurukul, such as "satyam vada, dharmam chara" (speak the truth, practise dharma).

💡 Core concepts

Isha Upanishad: key teachings:

- **Verse 1:** "Ishavasyam idam sarvam yat kincha jagatyam jagat; tena tyaktena bhunjitha, ma gridhah kasya svid dhanam."
- All this, whatever moves in the world, is pervaded by the Lord.
- Enjoy (protect yourself) through renunciation.
- Do not covet anyone's wealth.
- **Values:** everything belongs to the divine whole, so use things as a trustee, not an owner; enjoy with restraint; no greed.
- **Verse 2:** "Kurvann eveha karmani jijivishet shatam samah; evam tvayi nanyatheto'sti na karma lipyate nare."
- Doing works here, one should wish to live a hundred years.
- For you there is no other way; this way, action does not cling to a person.
- **Values:** an active, long life of duty without attachment (the root of karma yoga), not escapism.
- **Verses 6–7:** one who sees all beings in the Self and the Self in all beings hates none. For the one who sees this oneness, there is no delusion or grief. **Values:** universal love, equality, non-hatred.

- **Verses 9–14 (vidya and avidya, sambhuti and asambhuti):** pursuing only worldly knowledge or only spiritual knowledge leads to darkness; combining both, one crosses death through the first and attains immortality through the second. **Value:** balance of material and spiritual life (like science with values).
- **Verse 15:** "the face of truth is covered by a golden lid; remove it so that I may see the truth." **Value:** do not be blinded by glitter and wealth.

Taittiriya Upanishad: key teachings:

- **Shiksha Valli (education and conduct):**
- Phonetics and study.
- Values of a student and teacher.
- The convocation address (1.11):
  - "Satyam vada" (speak the truth); "dharmam chara" (practise dharma).
  - "Svadhyayan ma pramadah" (do not neglect study).
  - "Matri devo bhava, pitri devo bhava, acharya devo bhava, atithi devo bhava" (treat mother, father, teacher and guest as divine).
  - Give with faith, humility and understanding ("shraddhaya deyam").
  - Follow the good conduct of the wise, not their faults.
- **Brahmananda Valli:**
- "Satyam jnanam anantam brahma."
- The five koshas (food, vital air, mind, intellect and bliss), each inner one subtler than the outer, the self being innermost.
- **Ananda mimamsa:** a scale of bliss that grows a hundredfold at each level, showing that the joy of Brahman is far beyond any worldly pleasure.
- **Bhrigu Valli:**
- Bhrigu asks his father Varuna to teach him Brahman.
- Varuna tells him to find it through tapas (deep reflection).
- Bhrigu realizes step by step that Brahman is food (anna), then life (prana), then mind (manas), then understanding (vijnana), and finally bliss (ananda).
- **Teaching method:** self-inquiry and discovery rather than spoon-feeding.
- Also teaches: "annam na nindyat", do not despise food, and produce plenty of food and share it.
- **Mukti:** the one who knows Brahman, hidden in the cave of the heart, attains all desires together with Brahman. Knowledge of the true self beyond the five koshas is liberation, and it brings fearlessness ("anandam brahmano vidvan na bibheti kutashchana": the knower of the bliss of Brahman fears nothing).

Examples and comparisons

Example 9 (trusteeship). Gandhi said the first verse of the Isha Upanishad summed up his philosophy. A business owner who treats profit as held in trust for employees, customers and society, and pays fair wages, practises "tena tyaktena bhunjitha".

Example 10 (karma yoga at work). An engineer gives full effort to a project but does not fall into despair if a competitor wins the contract. Working without attachment to the result keeps the mind steady and

performance high.

Example 11 (convocation address today). At a university convocation, students are reminded: speak the truth, do your duty, keep learning, respect parents, teachers and guests, and give generously. These lines from the Taittiriya are still recited at many Indian convocations.

Key points to remember

- Isha: 18 verses, Shukla Yajurveda ch. 40; verse 1 (renunciation, no greed), verse 2 (work 100 years, karma yoga), 6–7 (oneness, non-hatred), 9–14 (vidya-avidya balance), 15 (golden lid).
- Taittiriya: Shiksha Valli (convocation address), Brahmananda Valli (satyam jnanam anantam, five koshas, ananda mimamsa), Bhrigu Valli (anna → prana → manas → vijnana → ananda).
- Mukti: knowledge of Brahman, fearlessness.

⭐ Important questions

1. Explain the teaching of renunciation and karma yoga in the Isha Upanishad, quoting the first two verses.
2. Discuss the human values taught in the Isha Upanishad (oneness, vidya-avidya, non-greed).
3. Explain the convocation address of the Taittiriya Upanishad and its relevance to students.
4. Explain the pancha kosha theory of the Taittiriya Upanishad, including Bhrigu's discovery.
5. What is mukti according to the Taittiriya Upanishad?

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UNIT 5 Varna, Ashrama, Pancha Maha Yajna, Samskaras and Vratas

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Varna:** a classification of social roles in Vedic thought (Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra), described in the Gita as based on qualities and actions (guna-karma).
- **Ashrama:** a stage of life; there are four: student (brahmacharya), householder (grihastha), retired life (vanaprastha) and renunciation (sannyasa).
- **Purushartha:** the four aims of human life: dharma (righteousness), artha (wealth), kama (desire, pleasure) and moksha (liberation).
- **Pancha maha yajna:** the five great daily duties of a householder towards knowledge, the divine, ancestors and parents, other beings and fellow humans.
- **Yajna:** literally sacrifice or offering; in a wider sense, any selfless action done for the good of all.
- **Samskara:** a rite of passage that refines and purifies a person at key stages of life; tradition lists sixteen.
- **Upanayana:** the sacred-thread ceremony marking the start of formal education with a teacher.
- **Vivaha:** the marriage samskara, the entry into the householder stage.
- **Antyeshti:** the last rites after death.
- **Vrata:** a vow or self-imposed discipline undertaken with resolve (such as truthfulness, fasting, silence).

💡 Core concepts

Varna:

- The Purusha Sukta (Rigveda 10.90) describes four varnas.
- The Bhagavad Gita (4.13) says "chaturvarnyam maya srishtam guna-karma-vibhagashah": the four varnas were made according to qualities and actions.

Varna	Role	Qualities emphasized
Brahmana	Teaching, research, guidance	Knowledge, self-control, purity
Kshatriya	Protection, governance	Courage, leadership, justice
Vaishya	Agriculture, trade, wealth creation	Enterprise, honesty in dealings
Shudra	Service, crafts, labour	Skill, dedication

In its ideal sense, varna was a division of work for a cooperative society, based on aptitude and not on birth. Over time it hardened into a birth-based caste system with discrimination and untouchability, which reformers (Buddha, Basavanna, Dayanand Saraswati, Gandhi, Ambedkar) criticized. The Indian Constitution (Articles 14–17) guarantees equality and abolishes untouchability. The lasting value is that every kind of work is necessary and dignified, and each person should develop their aptitude.

Ashrama system (life stages, about 25 years each in the ideal of a 100-year life)

Ashrama	Stage	Main duty
Brahmacharya	Student life	Learning, discipline, celibacy, service to the teacher
Grihastha	Householder	Earning by right means, family, supporting all other ashramas, the five great duties
Vanaprastha	Retired life	Gradual withdrawal, guiding the young, study and service
Sannyasa	Renunciation	Freedom from attachments, pursuit of moksha, teaching society

The ashramas balance the four purusharthas: artha and kama are pursued within dharma during grihastha, and moksha becomes the focus later.

Pancha maha yajna (five great daily duties)

Yajna	Debt or duty to	Practice and modern form
Brahma yajna (rishi yajna)	Sages and knowledge	Daily study and teaching, sandhya; reading good books, sharing knowledge
Deva yajna	Divine forces of nature	Havan or agnihotra; respecting and protecting nature (air, water)
Pitri yajna	Ancestors and parents	Caring for living parents and elders, remembering ancestors
Bhuta yajna (bali vaishvadeva)	Other living beings	Feeding animals and birds, kindness to all creatures, protecting environment
Nri yajna (manushya or atithi yajna)	Fellow humans and guests	Hospitality, helping the needy, social service

They remind a householder of five debts: what we have comes from teachers, nature, parents, other beings and society, so we must give back every day.

Sixteen samskaras (shodasha samskara): the list varies by text. A common list (as in Swami Dayanand's Sanskar Vidhi) is:

1. Garbhadhana: conception.
2. Pumsavana: healthy development of the foetus.
3. Simantonnayana: care of the mother in pregnancy.
4. Jatakarma: birth.
5. Namakarana: naming.
6. Nishkramana: first outing.
7. Annaprashana: first solid food.
8. Chudakarana (mundan): first haircut.
9. Karnavedha: ear piercing.
10. Upanayana: sacred thread, start of formal education.
11. Vedarambha: beginning Vedic study.
12. Samavartana: completion of education (convocation).

3. Vivaha: marriage.
4. Vanaprastha: entering retired life.
5. Sannyasa: renunciation.
6. Antyeshti: last rites.

Other lists include Vidyarambha (starting to learn letters) and Keshanta (first shave) in place of Vanaprastha and Sannyasa.

Purpose of samskaras: mark transitions, give responsibilities, build family and social bonds, instil values at each stage, attend to health (prenatal care, nutrition), and remind the person of life's goals.

Vratas (vows):

- **Purpose:** to strengthen will power and self-discipline.
- **Yajurveda 1.5:** "agne vratapate vratam charishyami... idam aham anritat satyam upaimi" (O Agni, lord of vows, I will observe a vow; may I succeed; I move from untruth to truth).
- **Examples:**
- Satya vrata (truthfulness).
- Brahmacharya vrata (self-control).
- Fasting on chosen days (such as ekadashi) for health and restraint.
- Mauna (silence).
- Vows of study, service or giving up a bad habit.
- **Value:** small, steady vows build character, the same principle as forming good habits today.

Examples and comparisons

Example 12 (pancha maha yajna in a modern day). Morning: read 20 minutes of a good book (brahma yajna) and water the plants (deva yajna). Call or help your parents (pitri yajna). Keep a bowl of water for birds in summer (bhuta yajna). Help a junior with a problem or welcome a guest warmly (nri yajna).

Example 13 (ashrama planning). An engineer plans: study and skill-building till 25 (brahmacharya), career and family with honest earning (grihastha), mentoring and social work after 55 (vanaprastha), and finally simple, detached living. This gives life a purpose beyond only earning.

Example 14 (a 40-day vrata). A student vows to wake at 6 a.m. and avoid social media until noon for 40 days. Keeping a vow strengthens resolve, the core idea of vrata.

Key points to remember

- Varna: guna-karma (Gita 4.13), ideal division of work, not birth; constitutional equality; dignity of labour.
- Four ashramas and four purusharthas; grihastha supports all.
- Five great duties: brahma, deva, pitri, bhuta, nri yajna (five debts).
- Sixteen samskaras (know the list and purpose); upanayana, samavartana, vivaha, antyeshti.
- Vrata: "anritat satyam upaimi"; discipline and habit-building.

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⭐ Important questions

1. Explain the varna system as described in Vedic literature and its relevance and distortions.
2. Explain the four ashramas and their relation to the purusharthas.
3. Explain the pancha maha yajna and its relevance in modern life.
4. What are samskaras? List the sixteen samskaras and explain the purpose of any four.
5. What is a vrata? Explain its role in building character.

Last-hour checklist

☐ Vedas, layers, Vedangas, Upavedas; six darsanas table; Nyaya 16 padarthas, 12 prameyas, 4 pramanas, five-member syllogism (hill-fire), liberation chain; vada vs jalpa vs vitanda.

☐ Vaisheshika six padarthas plus abhava; nine dravyas; atomism; dharma definition (abhyudaya and nihshreyasa); asatkaryavada and three causes; adrishta; removing raga-dvesha.

☐ Samkhya 25 tattvas table; three gunas; satkaryavada; three sufferings; kaivalya. Yoga 1.2; 5 vrittis; 5 kleshas; 8 limbs; samyama. Vedanta atma, 5 koshas, sadhana chatushtaya and six virtues.

☐ Isha verses 1, 2, 6–7, 9–14, 15; Taittiriya three vallis, convocation address, satyam jnanam anantam, Bhrigu's five steps, mukti and fearlessness.

☐ Varna (Gita 4.13) with critique; ashramas and purusharthas; five great duties table; sixteen samskaras; vratas (anritat satyam upaimi).

Books prescribed by AKTU

These are the books named in the official AKTU syllabus. Buy or borrow them through a bookshop or your college library. The WorldCat links show which libraries hold a copy.

#	Title	Author(s)	Publisher	Where to get it legally
1	Sankhya Darshanam and Vedanta Darshanam	Udayveer Shastri	Govindram Hasanand	WorldCat
2	Patanjal Yog Darshan Bhashyam	Rajveer Shastri	Arsh Sahitya Prachar Trust	WorldCat
3	Samkhya Karika	Ishvarakrishna	Various editions	WorldCat
4	The Six Systems of Indian Philosophy	F. Max Müller	Longmans, Green (1928 edition)	WorldCat
5	The Nyaya Sutras of Gotama	Ed. Nandalal Sinha	Motilal Banarsidass (1990)	WorldCat
6	A Foundation Course in Human Values and Professional Ethics	R. R. Gaur, R. Asthana, G. P. Bagaria	Excel Books (2019)	WorldCat

Syllabus source: AKTU Open Elective-III and IV syllabus for B.Tech 8th semester, 2025-26 (copy hosted by an affiliated college, PDF)

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